Srinivasa Acharya

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The Power of Mahaprabhu's Mercy

Srinivasa Acharya is the one who brought the books of the Gosvamis of Vrindavana to Bengal. His father named him in obedience to the word of Mahaprabhu Himself; and from the day Srila Jiva Gosvami gave him the title “Acharya,” the Vaishnavas have called him Sri Srinivasa Acharya Prabhu, or simply Sri Acharya Prabhu. Narottama in his songs calls him Acharya Thakura, others Srinivasa Thakura, while King Vira Hambira, not yet knowing his name, called him in his mind the “granthacharya,” the master of the books.

Nityananda's son Virabhadra, in a letter to him (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” wave 14), says that Srinivasa is the power of Mahaprabhu's mercy. One power of Gaurasundara, His most intimate, is Sri Rupa: in Vraja he composed the books and set down in them the Lord's innermost desire. Another power is Srinivasa: he carried the books of Rupa and the other Gosvamis to the assemblies of the Vaishnavas of Gauda. The “Karnananda” says the same: Mahaprabhu manifests two of His shaktis — Rupa to write the books and Srinivasa to spread them. The Lord's design is one: through Rupa and the Gosvamis to reveal the books, through Srinivasa to give them out; and so Srinivasa is the same power of Gaura as Rupa, only turned toward distribution.

He is an associate both of Gaura's pastimes and of the pastimes of Vraja. For Jiva Gosvami he was “one of his own” (nija-jana), and Jiva himself called him “mahattama,” the greatest. Even before his birth the Lord, according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” called him the embodiment of His own pure love (see below); he is also called an avesha-avatara of Mahaprabhu, and it is said that only one whom he especially blesses can describe his deeds. The devotees of Puri, seeing the young Srinivasa's love for Gaura, understood that he was Gaura's own power, through whom Chaitanya's teaching and the shastras would be preached.

When the Gosvamis of Vrindavana had departed, Srinivasa, with Narottama and Shyamananda, preserved their legacy and widened Mahaprabhu's movement in Bengal. These three are called “the three acharyas,” the threefold power of the Lord's mercy, and to this day both householder and renounced Vaishnavas honour them as acharyas of the whole Gaudiya sampradaya.

The Prophecy at Puri

Srinivasa's father, Gangadhara Bhattacharya, was a Vaishnava brahmana of the village of Chakhandi on the bank of the Ganga, a Rarhi brahmana of high family; Karnapura Kaviraja names his line as Ratiya Ghanteshvari. Chakhandi (Chakhundi) lies near Kantakanagara, that is, Katwa, north of Agradvipa in the Nadia district; today one reaches it from Daihat station on the Bardhaman–Katwa railway. Until the age of fifty Gangadhara had no son.

When the Lord accepted sannyasa at Katwa, Gangadhara was there. He saw the barber Madhu weeping as he shaved the Lord, and the crowd sobbing; at the sight he fell senseless. Hearing the Lord's new name — Sri Krishna Chaitanya — he began to repeat it endlessly through his tears, crying, “Ha Chaitanya!” Forgetting to bathe or eat, intoxicated by that name, he went back to Chakhandi. People took him for a madman, but the discerning saw that he had gone mad with love for Chaitanya, called him Sri Chaitanya Dasa, and said that Chaitanyadeva Himself would cure him. The name stayed with him.

His wife, Lakshmipriya-devi, was the daughter of Balarama Vipra of Yajigrama, near Shrikhanda. Balarama was a pandita learned in jyotisha; he foresaw that a mahapurusha would be born of his daughter.

Once Chaitanya Dasa set out with his wife for Nilachala. On the way they stayed some days in Yajigrama with her father. Indifferent to the world, Chaitanya Dasa longed for one thing only — to see the Lord's moonlike face; but by the Lord's will a desire for a son also awoke in him then, and his wife herself urged him to go to Puri and ask for Mahaprabhu's blessing.[1]

The Lord was already waiting for them at the Lion Gate. Before they could speak He said, “Jagannatha will fulfil all your desires,” sent them with Govinda for darshan of Jagannatha and gave them lodging. The devotees wondered what the brahmana had prayed for and asked Govinda to find out; but the Lord Himself called Govinda and, absorbed in divine emotion, declared:

“This brahmana came desiring a son; a son named Srinivasa will be born to him. Through Sri Rupa and others I shall reveal the shastras of bhakti, and through Srinivasa I shall distribute the jewels of the books. Srinivasa is the embodiment of My pure prema; seeing him, all will rejoice at heart. Let the brahmana go quickly to Gauda.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 2.120–124)

That same night Jagannatha appeared to Chaitanya Dasa in a dream and told him to return home, for a son would soon be born to him. The Lord told the couple not to delay, to go to Gauda and to perform nama-sankirtana constantly. Chaitanya Dasa did so on his return, and sankirtana became the custom of his village and of the neighbouring ones. The villagers, who had once shunned the childless couple, now praised their good fortune.

Childhood

On the purnima of the month of Madhusudana (Vaishakha-purnima), under the nakshatra Rohini, a son of wondrous form appeared on Lakshmipriya's lap at Chakhandi.[2] His body shone like molten gold; a long nose, eyes reaching to the ears, a broad chest, arms down to the knees — he bore every sign of a mahapurusha. Chaitanya Dasa dedicated the infant to Mahaprabhu. At the birth festival the brahmanas were generously rewarded, and when the mother took her son on her lap, everyone began to sing the names of Gaura.

A few days later came the festival of the first feeding of rice and the name-giving, and the first tonsure was also performed. Remembering Gaurasundara's words, the father named the boy Srinivasa. The Lord's associates of the region — Govinda Ghosha, and Narahari with Raghunandana from Shrikhanda — showered their blessings on the child.

From his earliest years his mother taught him the holy names:

“‘Come, my son, say: “Gaura Vishvambhara, husband of Lakshmi and Vishnupriya, son of Shachi, Lord of Gadadhara's life, Master of Srivasa, Sri Krishna Chaitanya, Nityananda-Haladhara.” Come, say: “Sri Advaita Prabhu, the merciful.” Come, say: “Radha-Krishna, son of Sri Nanda, Govinda, Gopinatha, Madanamohana”’ — so she says the names of the Lord and His associates. Hearing this, Srinivasa in great joy pronounces some and cannot pronounce others.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 2.176–180)

From his mother he learned devotion to Chaitanya, Nityananda, Advaita and Their associates, and came to love singing of Gaura.

After the rites of chudakarana and upanayana he studied under Dhananjaya Vidya-vachaspati and in a short time mastered grammar, lexicography, poetics and logic; his grasp of the shastras too was remarkably deep.

As a boy he often visited the devotees of Gaura who lived around Chakhandi and heard about His virtues. Govinda Ghosha told him of Gaurasundara's pastimes, and all the devotees of Shrikhanda loved him dearly. Narahari, passing through Yajigrama with his companions on the way to bathe in the Ganga, bestowed his mercy on him. At home his father told him of Mahaprabhu's pastimes, of the Vrindavana pastimes of Radha and Krishna, of the lives of Sanatana and Rupa and their love for Gaura-Krishna; often father and son were overcome with ecstasy together. So, hearing of Gaura-Govinda from mother, father and neighbouring Vaishnavas, the boy, devoted to his parents, grew up, and soon eternal love for Gaurasundara awoke in him.

Chaitanya Dasa left the world while his son was still young. Srinivasa was crushed and for some time took neither food nor water; the devotees consoled him and his mother. Then, taking leave of the Vaishnavas of Chakhandi, he moved with his mother to his grandfather's house in Yajigrama, so as always to be in the company of the Gaura-loving devotees of Shrikhanda. The people of Yajigrama welcomed them gladly; its panditas and brahmanas marvelled at the young man's learning and devotion, but he himself thought only of Chaitanya's feet.

News of the Lord's Disappearance

Srinivasa resolved to go to Nilachala to see the feet of Mahaprabhu and His associates, and came to Shrikhanda to ask leave of Narahari and the other devotees. There he fell at Narahari's feet and rolled on the ground; his voice broke. Narahari embraced him and revealed that the Lord would soon conclude His earthly pastimes: this, he said, was what Advaita Acharya's “riddle” pointed to. At first Narahari and Raghunandana advised him to wait a few days and go with the Bengali devotees; but then Narahari told him not to delay a moment.

Having received the order and blessing of the devotees of Shrikhanda, Srinivasa took leave of his mother. Seeing his determination, she blessed her son, and on Magha shukla-panchami he set out for Nilachala with the Bengali pilgrims.

On the way he heard that Gaurasundara had disappeared. He fell senseless, and when he came to, he resolved to give up his body:

“Hundreds of times he strikes his head, tears out his hair, rakes his chest with his nails. Weeping and weeping, he curses himself; at his laments stones melt. Again and again he falls unconscious to the ground; at the sight of his tears everyone's heart breaks. In great torment the day ended; he firmly resolved: ‘I will not keep life in this body. I shall build a fire and enter it — then this cruel anguish of mine will end.’” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 3.66–70)

Then Mahaprabhu brought sleep upon him and appeared to him in a dream. Nrisimha Kaviraja writes in one of his verses that the Lord, seeing His devotee's suffering, consoled him with many merciful words and told him to go on to Nilachala. His disciple Karnapura Kaviraja, in the “Guna-lesha-suchaka” — “A Hint of a Fraction of His Virtues,” whose verses are preserved in the “Narottama-vilasa” — recalls the same journey:

“He appeared in the house of a foremost brahmana of the Ghanteshvara line of the Rarhi brahmanas; with a pure intellect expert in many shastras he conquered his opponents while still a boy; hearing that the feet of Shachi's son were manifest at Niladri, he gave up everything — may he, Sri Srinivasa Prabhu, my ocean of mercy, be victorious! Going to Sri Purushottama, he heard on the way of Chaitanya's disappearance; falling senseless, tearing his hair, striking his head and reproaching himself, he placed His feet in his heart and went on to Nilachala by himself — may he, Sri Srinivasa Prabhu, my ocean of mercy, be victorious!” (“Narottama-vilasa,” 2.73–74)

In Nilachala

Obeying the dream, Srinivasa came to Nilachala. He arrived in the afternoon, spent the night with a panda near the Lion Gate, and in the morning went to the house of Gadadhara Pandita. In Puri he had another dream: he saw Jagannatha, Subhadra and Balarama, and with Them Chaitanya and His associates.

Gadadhara Pandita, Ramananda Raya, Sarvabhauma, Vakreshvara, Paramananda Puri, Shikhi Mahiti, Vaninatha Pattanayaka, Govinda, Shankara, Gopinatha Acharya — all the Lord's associates, having given up sleep and food, were absorbed in chanting the name, form, qualities and pastimes of Gaurasundara. Ramananda Raya came to Sarvabhauma's house; both were drowning in grief, but on seeing Srinivasa they rejoiced ("Bhakti-ratnakara," 3.155–158). The devotees gave him important instructions, and at parting all embraced him.

Srinivasa fell at Gadadhara's feet; Gadadhara embraced him, and both sank into an ocean of divine emotion, while Srinivasa wept in separation from Gauranga. The "Bhakti-ratnakara" says that Gadadhara, in separation from the Lord, lived on only to bestow his mercy on Srinivasa (3.142–146). After going round the holy place, Srinivasa saw Gopinatha, Gadadhara's Deity, and, hearing the "Bhagavatam" explained from his lips, somehow kept life in his body. After a short stay with him he returned to Gauda at Gadadhara's command.

By then Raghunatha Dasa, maddened by separation after the departure of Gaurasundara and Svarupa, had already gone to Vraja, and King Prataparudra's grief was beyond words. Srinivasa came to the samadhi of Haridasa Thakura and wept there in anguish. He also saw Govinda, the Lord's servant, who had grown so thin that it seemed the wind would knock him down. Seeing in Srinivasa the future chief preacher of Mahaprabhu's teaching, Govinda embraced him with great love; after that Govinda did not live long.

New Bereavements

Back in Shrikhanda, Srinivasa began to tell Narahari Sarakara Thakura, Raghunandana and the other devotees of Mahaprabhu's disappearance — and fell senseless. He could not live away from Gadadhara and resolved to go back to Nilachala and stay with him, even against his command. But on the road travellers from Nilachala told him that Gadadhara Pandita had disappeared, and Srinivasa fell senseless. In a dream Sri Gaura and Gadadhara appeared to him and told him to go to Vrindavana by way of Navadvipa.[3]

Already on the Gauda road he learned that Nityananda and Advaita too had departed. His grief was indescribable: he fell on the road, wept all night and again wished to give up his body. But in the night Nityananda and Advaita appeared to him in a dream, consoled him and dissuaded him.

Navadvipa, Shantipura, Khardaha, Khanakula

In Navadvipa Srinivasa wept in separation from Gaura. At Gadadhara's direction he came to Mayapura and at the Yogapitha, the Lord's house, saw Vishnupriya and the aged Ishana. In Mahaprabhu's house Vamshivadana met him. Before any introduction, Vamshi knew who stood before him:

"Sri Vamshivadana, seeing him, without any introduction thought to himself, 'This must be Srinivasa.' Coming near, he asked who he was; Srinivasa told him everything from beginning to end. Sri Vamshivadana embraced him and bathed Srinivasa in his own tears. Srinivasa, falling to the ground, wishes to bow down, but Sri Thakura Vamshi will not release him from his embrace. To inform Sri Ishvari, Mother Vishnupriya, Sri Vamshivadana went [to her] with care." ("Bhakti-ratnakara," 4.20–24)

Vamshi took the youth on his lap, and, seeing his despair, asked Vishnupriya to give him darshan and her blessing. At first she refused and agreed only at Vamshi's persistent entreaty; she told Srinivasa to stay and accept prasada (this is told in detail in the article on Vishnupriya).

From then on Srinivasa came to her every day and saw her service. Giving up sleep and rest, she chanted the Name for eight watches, counting the names with grains of rice; these grains she cooked, offered to the Lord, and ate only a morsel. Srinivasa marvelled at the renunciation and faith of Mahaprabhu's consort; in a dream at Navadvipa Shachi-devi too appeared to him and blessed him. Having received Vishnupriya's loving blessing and instructions and the mercy of the devotees of Navadvipa, he visited Murari Gupta, Srivasa Pandita, Damodara Pandita, Sanjaya, Shuklambara and Gadadhara Dasa, and went on to Shantipura.

At Shantipura, in Advaita's house, he was blessed by Sita-devi, who could barely keep life in her body in separation from Chaitanya. At Khardaha Parameshvari Dasa brought him to Vasudha and Jahnava, and they showed him their mercy; Jahnava placed her feet on his head, and Virabhadra too blessed him. After staying a few days, he received from Jahnava the order to go to Vrindavana.

At Khanakula he came to the feet of Abhirama Thakura. Abhirama struck him three times with his whip "Jaya-mangala," and Abhirama's wife Malini held back his hand: "Srinivasa is still a boy — he cannot bear it." From those strokes Srinivasa was filled with love for Krishna. Abhirama loved him greatly and blessed him abundantly, and Srinivasa was like a disciple to him, though he never took initiation from him. And earlier, on the road to Khanakula, an old brahmana of that place, meeting Srinivasa, spoke to him thus of Abhirama:

"O Srinivasa, how much shall I tell you? He descended in a brahmana's house to deliver living beings. He is learned in all the shastras, supremely charming, an incomparable master of dance, song and music." ("Bhakti-ratnakara," 4.105–106)

Thus Srinivasa went round the homes of the associates of Mahaprabhu and Nityananda — Shantipura, Khardaha, Khanakula-Krishnanagara, Shrikhanda — and all, seeing his devotion, told him to go to Vrindavana. From Khanakula he came again to Narahari and Raghunandana in Shrikhanda, and then home to Yajigrama, where he told his mother of Jahnava's order. Lakshmipriya could not refuse her son, seeing how he yearned for the land of Krishna and the Gosvamis, and gladly blessed him.

The Road to Vraja

On a shukla-dvitiya Srinivasa set out for Vrindavana. He went by way of Agradvipa, Katwa, Maureshvara and Ekachakra — places of the pastimes of Gaurasundara and His associates — and lingered long among them. At Gaya he bowed to the feet of Vishnu, where Mahaprabhu had met Ishvara Puri and taken initiation. At Kashi he stayed in Chandrashekhara's house and heard of the Lord's pastimes from him and Tapana Mishra. Then came Ayodhya and Prayaga, and at Mathura he bathed at Vishrama-ghata and saw the birthplace of Krishna and Adikeshava.

On the way brahmanas told him that Rupa, Sanatana, Raghunatha Bhatta and Kashishvara had already left the world. Srinivasa fell senseless. But in a dream Sanatana, Rupa and the other departed Gosvamis said to him (so Nrisimha Kaviraja writes in the "Navapadya"): "This is no time for grief — Gopala Bhatta is here. Take from him the supreme Gopala mantra and our books, go to Gauda, preach there Mahaprabhu's teaching as the followers of Svarupa and Rupa received it, and teach the Vaishnavas." The brahmanas brought him to Jiva. Raghunatha Dasa, Gopala Bhatta and Jiva were still living, and he received the blessings of all three.

Vrindavana: Jiva and Gopala Bhatta

Srinivasa reached Vrindavana on Vaishakha-purnima and, after the evening arati in the temple of Govindadeva, fell at Jiva's feet. Jiva had already heard of him. He embraced the young man and asked about the Vaishnavas of Gauda; prasada was brought by Krishna Pandita, Govinda's servant, and Srinivasa honoured it together with Jiva. Jiva gave him lodging in a secluded place and entrusted him to his own Deities, Radha-Damodara.

Then Jiva took him to Gopala Bhatta, let him see Gopala Bhatta and his Deity Radha-ramana, and introduced him to Lokanatha, Bhugarbha, Paramananda and Madhu Pandita. On another day, at Gopala Bhatta's direction, Jiva bathed Srinivasa in the Yamuna and brought him to him, and Gopala Bhatta gave him the mantra of initiation. Seeing his eagerness and sincerity, the guru blessed him: “May every perfection be yours.”[4] Of Gopala Bhatta's disciples three became famous: Harivamsha “by contrast,” for his guru rejected him; Srinivasa in Gauda; and Gopinatha Pujari in Vrindavana (the service of Radha-ramana is still in the hands of Gopinatha's descendants). More on Gopala Bhatta and his disciples is in the article on him.

The morning after his initiation Srinivasa went with Jiva to Radha-kunda; Gopala Bhatta himself sent him to Raghunatha Dasa. There he saw Raghunatha Dasa, Raghava Gosvami and Krishnadasa Kaviraja, and for three days received instruction from them on bhajana. The austerity of Raghunatha Dasa and his absorption in love amazed him.

So Srinivasa became the initiated disciple of Gopala Bhatta and the instructed disciple of Jiva. He belongs to Sri Rupa's own circle and by his conduct and preaching proved himself the best of the rupanugas. In a song of Narahari Chakravarti, Gopala Bhatta is plainly called “the guru of Srinivasa Acharya.”

The Title “Acharya”

Once Jiva was explaining a verse of the “Ujjvala-nilamani” from the section on uddipana-vibhava — what awakens loving emotion — and asked Srinivasa its meaning and the feeling within it. By Rupa's mercy Srinivasa's explanation was so beautiful that Jiva and the Vaishnavas were astonished: without Rupa's mercy, they admitted, no one could explain it so. With the consent of all the Vaishnavas Jiva joyfully gave him the title “Acharya.”[5] From then on, at Jiva's command, Srinivasa taught the Vaishnavas of Vraja the “Bhagavatam” and other shastras. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati writes in the “Anubhashya” (on CC, Adi 10.85) that Jiva, having taught Srinivasa, Narottama and Duhkhi Krishnadasa, who had come from Bengal, gave them the names “Acharya,” “Thakura” and “Shyamananda” and sent them back with all the books of the Gosvamis to preach the holy name and love for Krishna.

In those days Narottama came to Vrindavana from Kheturi. Srinivasa had only heard of him before; he met him in Jiva's ashrama, and from their first meeting they were friends for life; Jiva gave Narottama the title “Thakura Mahashaya,” and the two studied under Jiva together. Narottama and Srinivasa were “one in soul”; and yet Narottama in his songs begged Srinivasa for the company of his servant Ramachandra Kaviraja — which shows how much he loved Srinivasa himself. Srinivasa, Narottama and Ramachandra were of one heart and mind.

With Jiva's permission Srinivasa and Narottama went round the whole of Vraja-mandala with Raghava Gosvami, who showed them the places of the pastimes. Raghava Pandita, a brahmana from the south of India, is in Krishna's pastimes the gopi Champakalata. Narahari Chakravarti devoted the fifth wave of the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” the longest in the book, to this pilgrimage;[6] the account of the holy places, in it and in other waves, is often addressed straight to Srinivasa: “O Srinivasa, look…” — so of Sanatana at Mahavana (5.1777) and, in Navadvipa, of Nandana Acharya's house (12.2422). At Pavana-sarovara, by

Sanatana's hut, Uddhava Dasa and other Vaishnavas met them joyfully (5.1330–1335).[7]

When they returned, Duhkhi Krishnadasa, a disciple of Hridaya Chaitanya of Dandeshvara in Utkala, came to Jiva. That day Srinivasa and Narottama had a presentiment that they would soon gain a new Vaishnava friend — and he came. Jiva taught him the "Bhagavatam," gave him the name Sri Shyamananda, made him an acharya of the bhakti-shastras and entrusted him to Srinivasa. The three became friends for life.

For some time Srinivasa, Narottama and Shyamananda lived in Vrindavana as Jiva's instructed disciples: they studied the books of the Gosvamis at his feet, received detailed personal guidance from him, and lived by begging (madhukari). With Jiva's approval they set the order of kirtana. All three were great masters of music, skilled in the Delhi kalavati style, one in life and purpose, friends at heart, mature in the knowledge of the rasa of Vraja and in Vaishnava siddhanta.

The Books Go to Gauda

Meanwhile in Gauda, after Mahaprabhu's disappearance, confusion had set in. In the line of Nityananda Prabhu there was no worthy successor; Virachandra, independent by nature, did not reach all of Gauda with his preaching; discord arose among Advaita's descendants; the mahantas, the Lord's associates, were departing one after another. Bauls, sahajiyas, darveshes, sais and the like, hiding behind the names of Chaitanya and Nityananda, taught unfortunate people their own paths. Jiva, then the only Vaishnava acharya, decided to make Srinivasa, Narottama and Shyamananda acharyas who would restore pure bhakti in Gauda, and to send with them there the books of the Lord's associates. By training them and entrusting the books to them, he revived pure devotion in Gauda.

Jiva — at Gopala Bhatta's wish — proposed this to the Gosvamis of Vraja, and after deliberating they all decided to hand the books to Srinivasa and send him off without delay. Jiva called the three and said, "Take the books of the Gosvamis and go quickly to Bengal." This was in the year 1504 of the Shaka era; in sending them Jiva had in mind preaching both in Bengal and in Orissa.

Jiva and the Vaishnavas came to the temple of Govinda and prayed, "O Govindadeva, give Srinivasa the power to preach these books!" At that very moment a garland fell from Govinda's neck, and the pujari carefully handed it to Srinivasa. Seeing Govinda's mercy, Jiva and the other acharyas fixed the departure for Agrahayana shukla-panchami.

Before leaving, at Jiva's direction, Srinivasa received the order and blessing of Raghunatha Dasa, Gopala Bhatta, Bhugarbha, Lokanatha, Madhu Pandita, Krishnadasa Kaviraja and other acharyas and Vaishnavas; the three bowed to the three Deities of Vrindavana — Govinda, Gopinatha and Madana-mohana. A certain Vaishnava of Vrindavana named Ishana also blessed them; among those who saw them off were Govinda, Vani Krishnadasa and Uddhava Dasa ("Bhakti-ratnakara," 6.514). Taking leave, Srinivasa came to the samadhi of Raghunatha Bhatta and, bathed in tears, glorified him: Brihaspati himself would have praised his expositions of the shastras, his reading of the "Bhagavata" had no equal — even Vyasa and others would have longed to hear it — and the gods marvelled at his devotion; then, bowing to the ground, the travellers went to the temple of Govinda ("Bhakti-ratnakara," 6.452–457).[8]

Before many mahantas Jiva packed the books into a chest. A wealthy merchant of Mathura, at his request, paid for an ox-cart, a wooden chest, locked and proof against rain, and armed guards on foot in front and behind. Jiva accompanied the chest as far as Mathura. The travellers took the road by which Mahaprabhu and Sanatana had once gone from Nilachala to Vrindavana; they spent the nights in villages, sang sankirtana and preached. Among the books Jiva sent with Srinivasa was the "Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita"; shortly before, Srinivasa had received the title "Acharya."

Why does the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” name neither Srinivasa, the disciple of Jiva and of Gopala Bhatta, nor Narottama? Many answer that Kaviraja finished the book before their preaching began — and so the silence is natural.

The Theft at Vana-Vishnupura

Rumour of a rich merchant with a precious load reached the king of Vana-Vishnupura, Vira Hambira — king and leader of robbers. The king had his astrologer test the rumour, and he confirmed that the chest held treasure. The robbers worshipped Chandi and sent out a spy; the king ordered that no one be killed. The night was especially dark; the travellers, having taken prasada, slept by the river. The king's men carried off the chest and brought it to the palace.

In the morning the three searched everywhere in alarm and, finding nothing, were as if struck by lightning. Their grief was indescribable; they thought of giving up their lives. Then they said, “Who can fathom the will of Govindadeva?” — and remembered hearing from the Gosvamis that the king of Vishnupura was the chief of robbers. The local people at once suspected the king, and some advised Srinivasa to go to him straight away: the books were surely in Vishnupura. News came, too, that they lay in the royal storehouse. Learning that the books could be found through the king himself, the three gave up the thought of death.

Then Srinivasa sent Narottama to Kheturi and Shyamananda to Utkala, and himself resolved to go to the palace.[9] Knowing Lokanatha's wish, he said to Narottama, “Go quickly to Kheturi and fulfil Lokanatha's command” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 7.119).

Meanwhile in the palace the chest was opened — and instead of jewels there were only books. The king asked the astrologer how he could have been so wrong. On a palm leaf he read the name “Sri Rupa Gosvami,” and at the mere sight of Rupa's handwriting his sins vanished. The sight of the holy books purified him; he repented and wished to meet their owner — the “granthacharya” — lest he remain an offender against a saint. That night he dreamed of someone shining like a golden mountain — Srinivasa — who said, “Do not worry, I shall come soon. Life after life you are my eternal servant.”

Vira Hambira

In Vishnupura the brahmana Krishnavallabha, on seeing Srinivasa, surrendered at his feet, took him home and honoured him, and Srinivasa initiated him; others were initiated too. From Krishnavallabha Srinivasa learned that the king heard the “Bhagavatam” every day from a certain brahmana, and the next day Krishnavallabha brought him to the royal assembly as a great Vaishnava.

Seeing his wondrous form, the king fell at his feet and gave him a high seat and garlands. Srinivasa sang the guru-vandana and then, at the king's request, began to explain the “Bhagavatam”; after the explanation he sang and danced in kirtana. The king's heart melted. Srinivasa read the “Bhagavata” day after day, hoping to recover the books, and the king gave him a secluded dwelling. At last, when they were alone, Srinivasa told him of the loss. The king, weeping, begged forgiveness again and again and confessed how his robbers had carried off the chest and how he himself had been changed by opening it. With a straw between his teeth he fell at Srinivasa's feet; Srinivasa embraced him and said that Gauranga Himself would soon show him mercy. The king brought out the chest.

Srinivasa instructed him: “Sri Krishna Chaitanya has shown you mercy. Consider yourself an offender in every way and constantly perform nama-sankirtana,” — and gave him the Harinama maha-mantra. One glance at a great Vaishnava is enough to be purified: so the robber chief was purified by seeing Srinivasa. And Srinivasa himself saw in everything that had happened — the loss and the return of the books — only the boundless sweet mercy of Gaurasundara.

At the king's request he sent letters to the Gosvamis in Vrindavana and to Narottama and Shyamananda: the books were found, and the king's heart was changed. The news went to Jiva with the drivers and guards; Srinivasa filled the cart that had brought the books with articles for service and sent it back to Vrindavana. The Gosvamis marvelled at Srinivasa's deeds. At their command he began to spread the books in Gauda. In time the king and all his court took initiation from him and gave him their lives and wealth; at the king's initiation Srinivasa gave him the name Chaitanya Dasa (on his initiation into the yugala-mantra, see below).

Srinivasa preached both by explaining the “Bhagavata” and by kirtana, Narottama and Shyamananda chiefly by kirtana. Each of the three acharyas sang in his own style: Srinivasa in the manohara-shahi style, Narottama in garanhati, Shyamananda in reneti; these styles have not survived.

The “Prema-vilasa” (vilasa 13) relates that Krishnadasa Kaviraja, on hearing of the theft, decided that his “Chaitanya-charitamrita” was lost and threw himself into Radha-kunda. But no authoritative biography confirms this. And the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” itself records the Lord's judgement against suicide — both in the case of Raghunatha Dasa at Govardhana and of Sanatana, who wished to throw himself under the chariot:

“My dear Sanatana, if I could attain Krishna by suicide, I would at once and without hesitation give up My life millions of times over. Krishna cannot be attained merely by giving up the body. He is attained only by selfless worship and devotion. There is no other way.” (CC, Antya 4.55–56)

Jiva's letters, too, contradict the story: in them, written when Srinivasa already had sons, Jiva conveys to him the obeisances of Krishnadasa Kaviraja — so Kaviraja was alive long after Srinivasa, then still unmarried, had delivered the books. Such stories are interpolations contrary to siddhanta; of them see below.

The First Marriage

With the chest of books Srinivasa returned to Yajigrama, to his grandfather's house, and told the devotees everything. Here he learned of Vishnupriya's departure and fell senseless. Raghunandana called him to Shrikhanda; then Srinivasa again went round Katwa, Navadvipa and other holy places.

Narahari, Raghunandana and all the people of Shrikhanda loved him with a father's love. Srinivasa's mother, as his father had before, wished him to marry, and spoke of it to Narahari. Narahari, though he himself displayed renunciation, persuaded Srinivasa: “Obey your mother”; so Sri Sarakara Thakura arranged his marriage (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.883). Even earlier Srinivasa had received the same command in a dream from Advaita. Abashed, he agreed without waiting to be told twice. Gadadhara Dasa at Kantakanagara blessed him: “You will taste the nectar of the Lord's sankirtana among His associates; go and marry.” Raghunandana came to Yajigrama and arranged the wedding. Thus Srinivasa's marriage was arranged by Narahari and other renounced associates of Gaura.

On Vaishakha krishna-tritiya at Yajigrama he married Draupadi-devi, the devout daughter of Gopala Chakravarti.[10] Draupadi took from him the mantra of initiation and the name Ishvari. Gopala Chakravarti, though his father-in-law, accepted him as his guru even before the wedding; Gopala's sons too — Shyamadasa (also called Shyamananda) and Ramachandra (also called Ramacharana) — became Srinivasa's disciples. Narahari and Gadadhara Dasa especially rejoiced at his marriage.

In Yajigrama Srinivasa taught the books of the Gosvamis to many devoted disciples, and sincere souls flocked to him. Sri Dasa and Gokulananda, the sons of Dvija Haridasa, took initiation from him and studied with him.[11]

Ramachandra and Govinda Kaviraja

Once, as Srinivasa was explaining the “Bhagavatam” in his house at Yajigrama, Ramachandra, the son of Chiranjiva Sena of Shrikhanda, passed by — newly married, walking with his young wife. Seeing each other from afar, both felt a bond of friendship. Srinivasa asked about him and learned that he was a learned poet and physician from a family of physicians, a native of Kumaranagara. Ramachandra and his brother Govinda had been brought up by their grandfather, Damodara Kaviraja, a shakta, and had leaned toward shaktism. Next morning Ramachandra came and fell at Srinivasa's feet. Srinivasa embraced him and said, “Life after life you are my dearest friend; today a merciful Providence has brought us together again” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 8.544). Srinivasa began to teach him the books of the Gosvamis and a few days later gave him the Radha-Krishna mantra; out of love for him he also made him his personal servant.[12]

So Ramachandra Kaviraja — a famous physician, unbeaten in debate — became one of Srinivasa's most important disciples; Narottama names him again and again in the signature lines of the songs of the “Prarthana.” The title “Kaviraja” was given to him, as to his brother Govinda, by Jiva — so Srila Bhaktisiddhanta also writes in the “Anubhashya” (on CC, Adi 10.85).[13]

His brother Govinda, an ardent shakta, received a sign from Bhagavati (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” wave 9) and wished to take shelter of Srinivasa, but Srinivasa had already gone to Vrindavana. The devotees of Gauda sent Ramachandra after him, and Ramachandra told Govinda to move from Kumarahatta to Teliya Budhari. At the devotees' wish Srinivasa returned to Gauda and came to Budhari. Ramachandra and Govinda received him with pomp, and in Govinda's house Srinivasa initiated him into the Radha-Krishna mantra (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 10.171). Delighted with Govinda's songs, Jiva, Srinivasa and Jahnava gave him the title “kaviraja.”

The Second Visit to Vrindavana

When Shuklambara, Gadadhara Dasa and Narahari had departed, Srinivasa, grieving, went to Vrindavana again; there he learned that Dvija Haridasa too had passed away.[14] He travelled with many devotees by the old road — through Gaya, through Kashi, where he visited Chandrashekhara, through Mathura with its Vishrama-ghata and Adikeshava. Jiva was waiting for him, embraced him and asked about the Bengali Vaishnavas; Shyamananda also came from Puri. Srinivasa saw Gopala Bhatta, Bhugarbha, Lokanatha and others, heard from them of Gaura-Krishna, and they encouraged him.

Jiva taught Srinivasa and Shyamananda the conclusions of the newly completed “Shat-sandarbha,” began the “Gopala-champu” and read them its opening invocation. Srinivasa spent several months with Jiva and the Gosvamis. He summoned Ramachandra from Gauda and presented him to Jiva; at the direction of Srinivasa and Jiva, Ramachandra visited Govinda, Gopinatha, Madana-mohana and the samadhi of Sanatana. Then at Jiva's command Srinivasa and Shyamananda went to Gauda by way of Vana-Vishnupura; with the return of the three acharyas a wave of Hari-kirtana swept over Gauda.

Vishnupura: Kalachand

In Vishnupura the king danced for joy, honoured Srinivasa as his guru and gave a feast; Shyamananda marvelled at his devotion. Here Srinivasa initiated Vira Hambira into the yugala-mantra, the mantra of Radha-Krishna, and with Jiva's permission named him Sri Chaitanya Dasa. The queen and Prince Dhadi Hambira, who received the name Sri Gopala Dasa, were initiated too. The “Prema-vilasa” (vilasa 18) counts the “maharajadhiraja” Vira Hambira Simha of the royal Malla line as one of the branches of Srinivasa's “tree.”

Through Vira Hambira Srinivasa manifested the service of Sri Kalachand: by his mercy the king installed this Deity, and on the day of installation Srinivasa with his own hands performed the abhisheka, the puja and all the rites. Then Shyamananda went to Puri and Srinivasa to Yajigrama. King

Harinarayana of Shikhareshvara invited him and received him with honours; for several days Srinivasa explained the “Bhagavatam” there, and many received mercy.

Festivals of Separation

Narahari had departed on Agrahayana krishna-ekadashi, Gadadhara Dasa in Kartika. On returning to Gauda Srinivasa held festivals of separation for Gadadhara Dasa at Katwa and for Narahari at Shrikhanda, and then a great festival at his own home in Yajigrama. Of Gadadhara Dasa's day of departure the “Bhakti-ratnakara” says: “What shall I say of Kartika krishna-ashtami? On this day my Prabhu disappeared” (9.362); the festival Srinivasa held on that day was immense and as famous as the festival of Kheturi. At the festival for Narahari (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 9.512–514) Srinivasa performed the rites; Virachandra was there too, and Srinivasa explained the “Bhagavatam.” At the festival of Dvija Haridasa's departure, on Magha krishna-ekadashi, at Kanchanagaria, he initiated his sons Sri Dasa and Gokulananda.

Kheturi

When Narottama, at Lokanatha's command, manifested six pairs of Deities at Kheturi — Gauranga, Vallabhi-kanta, Vraja-mohana, Sri Krishna, Radha-kanta and Radha-ramana — Srinivasa, at Jahnava's direction, himself performed Their abhisheka, installation and first puja. This was on Phalguna-purnima.

The news of the festival reached Srinivasa at Budhari, in the house of Govinda Kaviraja, and everyone went with him to Kheturi; Srinivasa, his disciple Ramachandra and Ramachandra's brother Govinda worked actively for the festival, which was organised by Raja Santosha Datta. Srinivasa, Narottama and Santosha went out to meet the guests with garlands. Srinivasa offered Jahnava sanctified sandal paste and garlands, and at her bidding Nrisimha Chaitanya adorned Srinivasa, Shyamananda and Narottama. At dusk, in honour of Gauranga's appearance, Srinivasa performed the abhisheka and sang and danced all night; in the morning came the abhisheka, the puja and the offering of bhoga cooked by Jahnava. Jahnava asked Narottama, Srinivasa and Shyamananda to eat after the mahantas, and then distributed maha-prasada to all.

The festival was held under Jahnava's guidance; Srinivasa, Narottama, Shyamananda and the other acharyas honoured her as jagad-guru and felt they had reached the goal of life in hearing Hari-katha from her lips. Srinivasa and the other acharyas carried on sankirtana under the guidance of Jahnava and Vishnupriya. In the kirtana at Kheturi Mahaprabhu Himself appeared with His associates — this, says the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” was the mercy shown to Srinivasa and Narottama (10.605–607). The festival is described in detail in the article on Jahnava.

The “Prema-vilasa” (vilasa 19) writes that at Kheturi Srinivasa worshipped Gauranga with the Radha-Krishna mantra, that the Gosvamis had supposedly prescribed worship of Gaura with the ten-syllable Gopala mantra, that Jahnava approved, and that on Phalguna-purnima everyone took maha-prasada. This is an interpolation by a malicious opponent of the Gaura-mantra and of observing the day of Gaura's appearance. There is nothing of the kind in the “Bhakti-ratnakara”: it says the Deities were “worshipped with wondrous rites,” and Narottama bowed to each, calling Him by name: “O Gauranga! O Vallavikanta! O Sri Krishna! O Vraja-mohana! O Radha-ramana! O Radhe! O Radha-kanta! Obeisance to You!” (10.492–496). So each Deity was worshipped with a special mantra, His own: to the different manifestations of the Lord — form, name, associates, pastimes — correspond different mantras, as the shastras and the mahajanas confirm. Vilasas 19 and 20 are not genuine at all: of the four manuscripts from which the “Prema-vilasa” was published at Baharampur (Bengali year 1299), three end with the 18th. The book is in places corrupted by interpolations contrary to siddhanta — on Kaviraja's suicide, on worship of Gaura with the Radha-Krishna mantra and fasting on Gaura-purnima,

on the censure of Srinivasa's marriage — and these cannot be trusted.

After the festival Srinivasa and Shyamananda stayed a few more days at Kheturi and then returned to Yajigrama and celebrated there; Narottama came too, and then Shyamananda left for Utkala, having called at Srinivasa's house on his way from Kheturi. Jahnava, going to Vraja after the festival, met Srinivasa at Katwa on her return and stayed with him at Yajigrama, his home village; he brought her into his house and worshipped her. Virachandra too visited Yajigrama on his way to Vrindavana: Srinivasa worshipped him with devotion, honouring him as the Lord Himself — for Virabhadra, says the "Chaitanya-charitamrita," "is the Supreme Lord Himself," though He called Himself only a great devotee (Adi 11.9); and there was a great festival of sankirtana in Srinivasa's house.

Navadvipa with Ishana; Farewell to Raghunandana

With Narottama and Ramachandra, Srinivasa went round the nine islands of Navadvipa, which embody the nine forms of bhakti. The places of Gaura's pastimes, already dilapidated, were shown them by Ishana — the old servant of Mahaprabhu's house, who had outlived all the devotees of Navadvipa: "In Navadvipa hardly anyone remains but the Lord's servant Ishana" ("Bhakti-ratnakara," 11.721). Receiving his blessing and embrace, they went by way of Mayapura to Yajigrama.[15]

King Vira Hambira came to Yajigrama at that time to see his guru's feet. And Srinivasa, after visiting Shrikhanda and Budhari, came again to Kheturi and immersed himself in the nectar of sankirtana lasting eight watches. There even logicians and worldly men took shelter at his feet. In Yajigrama he accepted many disciples, discussed the shastras, sang sankirtana until he was hoarse, and many prominent unbelievers surrendered to him.

Once Raghunandana called Srinivasa to Shrikhanda. He foretold that times of kutarka would come and doubts would settle in people's hearts, but that those seeking their good would cross this ocean of doubt through Srinivasa's preaching, and that Gauranga would do great things through him ("Bhakti-ratnakara," 13.174–179). Raghunandana also recited to him verses of Narahari's "Sri-Krishna-bhajanamrita": when Krishna Chaitanya and Nityananda withdraw Their descent, all Vaishnavas — the highest, the middle and the lowest — will day by day be anxious, and their hearts will almost always be full of doubt (13.175–176). He blessed him: "Live long and preach the message of Sri Gauranga everywhere," and entrusted his son Kanai to his Deities; for three days sankirtana went on, and Raghunandana departed.[16] Together with Kanai Thakura Srinivasa held a festival of separation at Shrikhanda, and in the kirtana Raghunandana himself appeared, dancing. With a heavy heart Srinivasa returned to Yajigrama, and from there went to Vana-Vishnupura and spread kirtana there. The king and the people received him with honours; he gave classes in the palace, sang kirtana, and many in Vishnupura took his shelter.

The Second Marriage

In Vishnupura Srinivasa manifested the pastime of a second marriage. Raghava Chakravarti of Gopalpura in Radha had a virtuous daughter, Gauranga-priya. Unable to find a husband for her, Raghava prayed to the Deity of Mahaprabhu, and one night he and his wife Madhavi saw in a dream that their daughter was given to Srinivasa. At the same time Srinivasa too received in a dream Mahaprabhu's command to marry Gauranga-priya, and the girl herself chose him as her husband. Raghava came to Srinivasa and timidly asked leave to say why he had come; Srinivasa, understanding everything, smiled and agreed. The wedding was arranged by Vira Hambira with great splendour and at great expense.

With his young wife Srinivasa returned to Yajigrama. Just then Jahnava arrived there from Vrindavana. Srinivasa took the dust of her feet, worshipped her, and told Gauranga-priya to bow to her; Jahnava

embraced her, stayed with them a few days, and left for Khardaha.

Some interpolated verses of the “Prema-vilasa” try to belittle Srinivasa because of his marriages, and some modern writers hold that Narottama remained renounced while Srinivasa, once renounced, “fell” from the ideal by marrying twice and fathering several children. These are the judgements of the falsely and excessively renounced — offensive and contrary to bhakti. Ramachandra, the very soul of Narottama, accepted Srinivasa as his guru after his first marriage; Narottama himself in the “Prarthana” prays for his mercy; Srinivasa is honoured as an acharya by householders and renunciants alike; and his marriage was arranged by renounced associates of Gaura — Narahari and others — who rejoiced in it. Srinivasa's marriage is a pastime shown for instruction: those attached to home (grihavrata) must not imitate the guru, and the falsely renounced (tyagi-bruva) must not take a maha-bhagavata for a man attached to family and so deprive themselves of good. The deeds of Mahaprabhu's devotees are inconceivable to those who have not surrendered to the Lord and His devotees; pure devotees have no aim but the Lord's desire, and in their actions there is not a shadow of worldly desire.

One who only called himself his disciple — Rupa Kaviraja — called Srinivasa a “grihastha,” a family man. Srinivasa's daughter Hemalata Thakurani tore the kanthi beads from his neck, and since then all pure Vaishnavas have rejected him as the Bengali “atibadi.” Expelled from Vaishnava society, he founded the apasampradaya of the “ati-bari”: he taught that only a renunciant can be an acharya and that no householder may bear the title “Gosvami,” and, rejecting the rules of vidhi, distorted raganuga-bhakti. Vishvanatha Chakravarti fought his movement and refuted him in the “Sarartha-darshini,” his commentary on the Third Canto of the “Bhagavatam.”

Jiva's Letters

From Vrindavana Jiva sent Srinivasa two letters. In the first he reports the departure of Bhugarbha and the progress of the revision of the “Rasamrita-sindhu,” the “Madhava-mahotsava,” the “Uttara-champu” — the second part of the “Gopala-champu” — and the “Hari-namamrita-vyakarana,” and asks after Srinivasa's eldest son, Vrindavana Dasa, and his other disciples. The name “Vrindavana Dasa” had been given to the boy by Jiva himself as soon as news of his birth reached Vraja (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 14.19–20).

The second letter Jiva opens with the address “samasta-guna-prashasta-bandhuvara-shrinivasacharya-mahattameshu” — “to Srinivasa Acharya, the greatest, the best of friends, renowned for every virtue.” He tells of Vraja and of the revision of the “Vaishnava-toshani,” the “Durgama-sangamani” and the “Gopala-champu,” asks Srinivasa to correct the errors in the “Hari-namamrita-vyakarana” already sent with him, checking it against the bhashya and vritti, and writes that the “Uttara-gopala-champu” is written but still needs reflection. More on these letters is in the article on Jiva.

Children and Descendants

Srinivasa had three sons and three daughters. The “Karnananda” names the sons thus: “The eldest son is named Sri Vrindavana Acharya… Prabhu's middle son is Radhakrishna Acharya… The youngest son is named Sri Gati-Govinda” (1.125–128). Gati-Govinda is the author of the “Vira-ratnavali”; in its signature line he says, “At the priceless feet of Mahaprabhu Virachandra, Gati-Govinda, son of Srinivasa, speaks this.” Srinivasa's sons, like many of his disciples, became well-known song-poets (padakartas).

The same “Karnananda” lists the daughters in this order: Hemalata, “Prabhu's own daughter,” who had many disciples and disciples' disciples; Krishnapriya Thakurani; and Kanchana-latika (1.136–139).[17] After her father's departure Hemalata Thakurani preached pure bhakti with power. Yadunandana Dasa

in the “Radha-Krishna-lila-rasa-kadamba” calls her full of love for Radha and Krishna, Srinivasa's daughter, who gave him the dust of her feet.

Gati-Govinda's son was Krishna Prasada, and his son Jagadananda. Jagadananda had two wives: by the first was born Yadavendra, by the second Radha Mohana, Bhuvana Mohana, Gaura Mohana, Shyama Mohana and Madana Mohana; the descendants of Bhuvana Mohana live at Manikyahara (Murshidabad district). Srinivasa's aged great-grandson Radhamohana Thakura, in the first half of the eighteenth century, compiled the anthology of padas “Padamrita-samudra” and a Sanskrit commentary on it, the “Mahabhavanusarini”; for six months he led a debate and established the siddhanta of parakiya. Another descendant of Srinivasa, Madhusudana, was the guru of the author of the commentary “Kashika.”

Disciples

Srinivasa's disciple Ramachandra Kaviraja and Ramachandra's disciple Harirama Acharya, following his instruction, preached the siddhanta of the Gosvamis everywhere. Ramachandra was very dear to Srinivasa, and therefore Narottama loved him more than life; Vira Hambira, Srinivasa's disciple, regarded Ramachandra as his shiksha-guru. At the command of Narottama and Srinivasa, Ramachandra went once more to Vrindavana.

Yadunandana Dasa, a disciple of Hemalata,[18] rendered many books of the Gosvamis into Bengali verse and became a well-known padakarta. In his verses he says, “My Prabhu is Acharya Thakura, who generously gave away in Gauda the treasure of the pastimes of Radha-Krishna”; and in the “Govinda-lilamrita”: “Thakura Srinivasa Acharya and Hemalata are servants of Chaitanya Dasa; longing for their feet, Yadunandana, an ambashtha, speaks in the vernacular” (an ambashtha is one of the physicians' caste). He apparently heard the story of Gopala Bhatta from Srinivasa himself.

The “Prema-vilasa,” at the end of vilasa 18 (Baharampur edition), lists the branches of the “wish-fulfilling tree of Srinivasa.” Six Chakravartis — Sri Dasa, Gokulananda, Shyamadasa, Vyasa, Govinda and Ramacharana — are devoted to the study of the books of bhakti, to serving the Vaishnavas and to delivering people. Eight Kavirajas — Ramachandra, Govinda, Karnapura, Nrisimha, Bhagavan, Vallabha Dasa, Gopiramana and Gokula. Then Ramakrishna, called Chattaraja; Kumudananda, Kularaja; Radhavallabha, Mandala; Jayarama Chakravarti; Rupa Ghataka; Thakura Dasa, Thakura; and the maharajadhiraja Vira Hambira Simha of the Malla line. In all — eight kavirajas, twelve brahmanas and one king: twenty-one branches. A verse there also glorifies Govinda Kavindra: the fragrance of his poems about Krishna, like a spring breeze from the sandal mountain, intoxicates the bee-devotees at the wish-fulfilling tree of Jiva's feet and astonishes all in the groves of Vraja.

Srinivasa's disciples also included Krishnavallabha and others of Vishnupura, Gopala Chakravarti and his sons, the sons of Dvija Haridasa, Vira Hambira with the queen and Dhadi Hambira, and Ramachandra and Govinda Kaviraja; the “Prema-vilasa” and the “Karnananda” also call the poet Radhavallabha Dasa his disciple; and finally there was a would-be disciple, Rupa Kaviraja.

Writings, and Songs about Him

The “Karnananda” of Yadunandana Dasa mentions Srinivasa's padas and gives samples of them, and some ascribe one or two songs to him. The glory of the six Gosvamis may be understood from his “Shad-gosvami-ashtaka.” Ramachandra Kaviraja wrote his life — the “Srinivasa Acharyera jivana-charita.”

Karnapura Kaviraja in the “Guna-lesha-suchaka” praises him, repeating after each verse: “May he, Sri Srinivasa Prabhu, my ocean of mercy, be victorious!” The first two verses are given above; the third tells how, on his way, he came to Khanda:

“Going on his way, he came to the town called Khanda, bowed to the beloved of Chaitanya-chandra, the best of Thakuras, Sri Sarakara, and received his permission; then, bowing at the feet of Raghunandana, he went on, remembering him — may he, Sri Srinivasa Prabhu, my ocean of mercy, be victorious!” (“Narottama-vilasa,” 2.85)

The verses Ghanashyama Dasa cites also give material for Srinivasa's life.

The old poet Govinda Dasa, in the song “Jaya jaya Srinivasa gunadhama…,” glorifies Srinivasa, abode of virtues and saviour of the fallen: his body is fairer than gold, he is clad in silk, he utters the Name of love and expounds the “Bhagavata,” surrounded by his devotees and companions; “Radhe, Krishna, Govinda” never leaves his lips; he serves Chaitanya, relishes His pastimes, and in his hand is a wish-fulfilling tree of books.

Narottama in the “Prarthana” prays, “Be merciful, Sri Acharya Prabhu Srinivasa: Narottama Dasa begs for the company of Ramachandra.” And after Srinivasa's departure he composed the lament of separation “Ye anila prema-dhana…” — “Where has he gone, Prabhu Acharya Thakura, who brought the treasure of love and abundant mercy?”

Departure

Once Ramachandra Kaviraja, after spending some days with Narottama at Kheturi, left in great sorrow for Yajigrama, and soon the news came that Sri Acharya Thakura had gone to Vrindavana (“Narottama-vilasa,” vilasa 11). Ramachandra was constantly with him and passed away in Vrindavana after Srinivasa's departure; Narottama, receiving both tidings, composed his song of separation.[19] The biographies name neither the place nor the day of his departure; the Vaishnavas honour it on the Gaura-ashtami of the month of Damodara (Gopashtami).

With the departure of Srinivasa, Narottama and Shyamananda (and also Rasikananda), the third of the four “dark periods” of Bengali Vaishnavism set in: after the departure of Mahaprabhu, Svarupa, Ramananda, the six Gosvamis and the three acharyas came the time of the apasampradayas. Yet even in such times the succession of the rupanugas is not broken: acharyas are sometimes secluded bhajananandis, sometimes preaching goshthyanandis, and an acharya's power is not measured by the number of his disciples.

Mani-manjari

In the “Karnananda” Hemalata tells how Srinivasa remained three days in samadhi at Vishnupura: in the form of Mani-manjari he was searching for Sri Radha's nose-ring, lost in the water pastimes on the Yamuna, and Ramachandra, entering meditation, found it. So in Krishna's pastimes Srinivasa is Mani-manjari, a maidservant of Sri Radha.

Of the three acharyas who preached the holy name, Narottama is one, the other two being Srinivasa and Shyamananda; but it was Srinivasa who recovered the books. In the succession leading to Vishvanatha Chakravarti, Narottama stands “together with Shyamananda and Srinivasa.” And Jiva's teaching on parakiya is confirmed by the conduct and instructions of his disciples — Srinivasa, Narottama and Shyamananda. What the Lord foretold in Puri came true: through Rupa He revealed the books, and through Srinivasa He gave them to Gauda.

1. According to some biographies, Chaitanya Dasa went to Nilachala only to see the Lord, and the Lord Himself revealed his unspoken wish; according to others, he went precisely to ask Mahaprabhu for a son.

2. The year of his appearance — 1530 — is given by only one biography.

3. According to another biography, the news of Gadadhara's departure reached Srinivasa while he was still on the road from Puri, and that night Gadadhara appeared to him in a dream and consoled him.

4. According to another biography, Srinivasa himself humbly asked for initiation, and Gopala Bhatta gave him the mantra the next day in the temple of Radha-ramana.

5. According to another biography, he received the title “Acharya” for his knowledge of philosophy: in a short time he had mastered all the conclusions of the Gosvamis.

6. One biography speaks of “five chapters” of the “Bhakti-ratnakara” and a circuit of “64 kroshas” of Mathura-mandala; in the book itself the circuit of Vraja is a single wave, the fifth.

7. According to one biography, they came to the hut of Uddhava Dasa himself.

8. According to one biography, others pronounce this glorification and Srinivasa hears it; in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (6.456) it is Srinivasa himself who speaks.

9. According to one biography, Shyamananda went not to Utkala but to Ambika-Kalna (elsewhere in the same biography — to Utkala).

10. According to another biography, the wedding took place on Akshaya-tritiya in the month of Vaishakha.

11. According to another passage of the same biography, they were initiated later — at the festival on the day of their father's departure at Kanchanagaria (see “Festivals of Separation”).

12. According to one book, not accepted by all, on Ramachandra's wedding day Srinivasa spoke to him a few words on the transience of worldly life, and he never took up family life.

13. According to one passage of one biography, the title was given by Srinivasa himself on hearing Ramachandra's verses; according to another, by the Gosvamis of Vrindavana.

14. According to another biography, Narahari and Gadadhara Dasa departed only after Srinivasa's second visit to Vrindavana: on his return he learned of Narahari's departure only at Shrikhanda and fell senseless, and Raghunandana, seeing him, was a little consoled in his grief; of Gadadhara Dasa's departure he learned at Kantakanagara. The news of Dvija Haridasa's departure, according to the same biography, reached Vrindavana while he was there.

15. The biographies differ in the order of events: according to one — Kheturi, then the circuit of Navadvipa, Yajigrama, Shrikhanda, Budhari and Kheturi again; according to another — Kheturi, Yajigrama, Navadvipa, Shrikhanda; according to a third — Kheturi, the meeting with Jahnava at Katwa, Navadvipa, Raghunandana.

16. According to another biography, after the circuit of Navadvipa Srinivasa, with Narottama and Ramachandra, was going to Raghunandana at Shrikhanda and learned of his departure on the way.

17. According to one biography, the daughters were named Krishnapriya, Hemalata and Phulapi Thakurani, and the sons Vrindavana Vallabha, Radha Krishna and Sri Gati (Gita) Govinda.

18. So say plainly both the “Karnananda” (where the author himself names himself Hemalata's disciple) and one of the biographies.

19. According to another biography, Ramachandra was the first to depart, in Vrindavana, a few months later; the news reached Srinivasa, and he, unable to bear separation from his dear disciple, also entered the eternal pastimes of Radha-Govinda, and then Narottama composed “Ye anila prema-dhana.” Yet another biography says in one place that Narottama first received the news of Ramachandra's departure and only soon after that of Srinivasa, and in another that Ramachandra departed after Srinivasa.